

Embedded V2 in Old Gutnish

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Old Gutnish – the language

- Language spoken on the island of Gotland (9th–16th century)
- North Germanic language of the Eastern branch.
- Few studies (see overview in Jordan 2026:18–22).

Method

- Text: *Guta saga* (Peel 1999), 13th century; oldest text in Gutnish.
- All 216 clauses extracted and analysed.

Main findings

	Main clause		Sub.clause		total
	n	%	n	%	n
øV	9	6.9%	14	16.7%	23
SV	39	30.0%	39	46.4%	78
V2	82	63.1%	26	31.0%	108
V > 2	0		5	6.0%	5
total	130		84		214*

* + 2 imperative clauses

Main clauses

- No V2 violations in main clauses in the corpus → a strict V2 language (Holmberg 2015) (1).
- Fronted subordinate clauses are followed by a resumptive element → not embedded in the V2 structure (see Kiparsky 1995, Meklenborg Nilsen 2025).
- The finite verb precedes the negation in all main clauses (2) → the verb has moved across the NegP in the I-domain to a higher position → the finite verb moves into the C domain.
- The subject may precede or follow the negation.
- **There is obligatory V-to-C in main clauses.**

- (1) *Þa var Gutland so eluist, et þet dagum sank . . .*
then was Gotland so bewitched that it day sank
‘At that time, Gotland was so bewitched that it sank during the day . . .’
- (2) *þa aigiu ai gutar skatt ut giefa (. . .)*
then own.3.pl not Gotlanders tax out give
‘The Gotlanders then have the right not to hand over their tax.’

Subordinate clauses

- The majority of embedded V2 in subordinate clauses stem from relative clauses: 19/26 examples, but V2 is attested in both nominal and adverbial clauses.
- The finite verb always occurs to the left of the negation (unless the negation has been fronted) → V-to-C movement (4).
- **No main–embedded asymmetry with respect to the underlying structure.**

- (3) *Þa en ai kumbr byr i þairi frest . . .*
then if NEG comes wind in in specified.time
‘Then, if there was no wind before that specified time’
- (4) *Þa en gutar efla ai fylgia . . .*
then if Gotlanders be.able.to.3.pl NEG follow
‘Nevertheless, if the Gotlanders are not able to take part (. . .)’

	V1	SV	V2	V>2	tot
that-clause		7	1	3	12
relative	8	3	19	2	32
conditional	6	5	1		12
other		24	5		29
Total	14	39	26	6	85

Table 1: Types of subordinate clause

Relative clauses

	SV	V1	V2	V>2	Total
S		5	15	1	21
O	3	2	2		7
other			2	1	3
Total	3	7	19	2	31

Table 2: Word order in relative clauses

- Subjectless relative clauses allow for movement into the preverbal position → A’ movement → V2.
 - Force/recursive CP?
- (4) *Han var fyrsti kirkia i Gutlandi, sum __ standa fikk..*
she was first church in Gotland COMP __ stand got
‘It was the first church in Gotland that was allowed to stand.’
- (5) *innan þan staþ, sum nu kallar Petrs kirkiu.*
within that city COMP now call Peter’s church
‘within the city which we now call Peter’s church.’

Conclusions

- Both main and embedded clauses in Old Gutnish have obligatory V-to-C movement.
- The difference in surface structure is not a reflex of the underlying syntax.

